



for 70 years under Communist rule, has seen a resurgence since 1992, when the ancient practice was given protected status by the country's constitution. Known as Tengrism, it is regarded as Mongolia's national religion and part of its identity.

Voice of the earth

Alongside the growth of Neopaganism and New Age practices, Neoshamanism has gained ground in the West since the 1990s. Driven by their conviction that humans face an ecological crisis of their own making, New Agers find in Neoshamanism—with

its links to the natural world—one response to their belief that only a return to an original innocence can prevent people despoiling the earth. Neoshamanists also search for self-knowledge, and many adopt an eclectic path, whether working with totem or spirit animals, undertaking dream journeys and quests for visions, engaging in astral projection, meditating, or going into trances. This approach is resented by some who adhere to traditional teachings, particularly in cases where some Neoshamans demand payment in exchange for their services.

▲ Hand drum

This deerskin drum is decorated with an image of the Great Spirit honored by the Assiniboiné people of North America's Great Plains. Ritual drumming led by medicine men is part of their ceremonies, the most important of which is the sun dance held in spring.